KEY INSIGHTS:

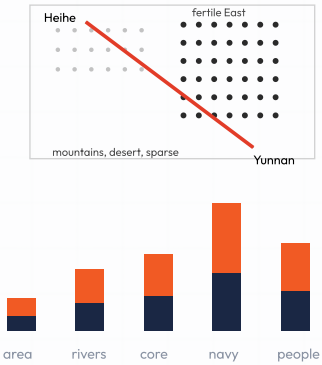
GEOGRAPHY

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

DATA 1

Heartland & the Hu Line

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated, the west is not. Terrain and climate concentrated people, food and power in one core.



DATA 2

Why one develops faster

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. China's map made unity cheap; Africa's makes it expensive.

1. Geography first
2. One core vs splits
3. Africa bigger in area
4. Unity was cheap

DATA 3

Buffer ring and the navy

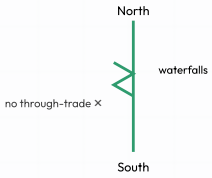
China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a by-product of the fertile east. Some of these regions are run as surveillance states, and the people living in them are unhappy. The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and jobs — a step Africa has never been able to take.



DATA 4

Natural barriers — a negative factor

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are expensive to build around these barriers, in contrast to the Han heartland. Trade routes never developed.



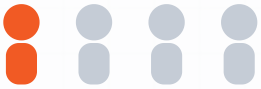
DATA 5

1 in 4 will be African

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural produce, but inevitably it cannot afford to. Political and religious clashes make it difficult to lower the bir...



1 in 4
will be African



1 in 4

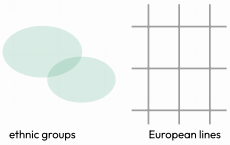
an extra billion people

DATA 6

Borders drawn by colonialism & war

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic instability. Contrast China's centralised core protected by buffer zones.





Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.